

FOREIGN POLICY OF PAKISTAN

PHASES OF PAKISTAN'S FOREIGN POLICY, PAKISTAN
IN INTERNATIONAL ORGANIZATIONS, CURRENT
FOCUSING POINTS, WAY FORWARD

Evolution from 1947-Current

First phase

- **1947-53:**
Exploration and Friendship with All
- **1953-62:**
Alignment with the West

Second phase

- **1962-71:**
Transition
- **1972-79:**
Bilateralism and Nonalignment
- **1980-90:**
Afghanistan and Partnership with the United States

Third Phase

- **1990-2001:** Post Cold War Era and Pakistan's Dilemmas
- **2001 Onwards:**
Counter Terrorism

PHASE ONE

Era of Neutrality 1947-1953

- The **international system** that emerged after Second World War was characterized by cold war and tight **bipolarity**. The foreign policy of the first few years of the existence of Pakistan can be labeled as the **non-aligned years**, because Pakistan was essentially trying to maintain neutrality in the ongoing cold war during this period. Both USA & USSR were inviting Pakistan for support in the cold war alignments.
- However Pakistan was itself beset with the task of putting things together in the promised land. It was confronted with all sorts of **economic, political and religious problems**. Pakistan during that period tried to overcome multiple security threats from **India and Afghanistan**.

Pakistan faced the following problems which affected its foreign policy resulting in its future economic and military dependence on foreign powers:

- **Hostile relations with India.**

In 1948 there was a war between the two countries on the Kashmir dispute. The matter was referred to the UN and under resolution passed by the Security Council, both countries agreed to hold plebiscite in Kashmir; however India refused to implement the resolution and Kashmir has been an occupied territory since.

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- Dispute between India and Pakistan over the **division of assets** and the **distribution of river water**.
 - After Pakistan's establishment, **Afghanistan demonstrated its hostility** and objected on Pakistan's membership in the UN.
 - At that time other Muslim countries were not strong enough to extend any military help.
 - It was cold war era and the big power's rivalry made the country territorially unprotected.

Because of the immediate security threats and weak military strength, Pakistan had 4 options to protect its security:

- To remain neutral
- To rely on the Muslim countries
- To join the Soviet bloc
- To join the Western Alliance System

Owing to 2 main reasons Pakistan opted for the fourth option:

- The US offered Pakistan to join the Alliance System which was meant to contain communism (State owning everything). Although the Western Alliance System was aimed to check the spread of Communism, yet Pakistan hoped to acquire substantial economic and military aid.
- The elite of Pakistan was under the western influence. A strong pro-west lobby had advocated Pakistan's joining the Western Alliance System. Ideologically, Pakistan was more akin to the US than to the Soviet Union.

PHASE II

Era of ALLIANCE 1954-1962

- Pakistan lived on developing with meager resources till 1955 and 1959 when Pakistan entered into a multilateral alliance system initiated by USA to contain communism. They were **South-East Asian Treaty Organization (SEATO-1955)** and **Central Treaty Organization (CENTO-1959)**. Pakistan felt secure because one of the clauses of both the agreements was “attack on one will be considered attack on all.”
- Pakistan and the US signed a Defense Pact in which US later guaranteed the security of Pakistan in the event of a communist attack. Pakistan's inclusion in Western Alliance System offended India, Afghanistan, Soviet Union and Egypt. Pakistan was termed as ‘US Protégé’ during the period of Alliances.

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- Although CENTO & SEATO were directed against the communist powers, yet Pakistan hoped to acquire western support to solve the Kashmir issue. The US did not put any pressure on India to hold plebiscite in Kashmir, moreover, few important developments forced Pakistan to reconsider its pro-western stand:-
 - The US spy plane incident of 1960 had exposed the insecurity of Pakistan in the event of the Soviet attack. The Khrushchev threatened to wipe out Peshawar from where U-2 had flown over the Soviet Union. The American bases in Pakistan had created embarrassment for Islamabad.

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- In **1962, Sino-Indo border war** forced Pakistan to seek alternate options than depending on the Western Alliance System. In US massive military support to India, notwithstanding reservations shown by Pakistan, added frustration among policy makers in Islamabad. Pakistan protested to the US that the American/Western military assistance to India would be used against Pakistan.
 - After 1962, the global political climate had changed from cold war to **peaceful coexistence**- CENTO and SEATO were the legacies of the cold war and after a political settlement between the US and Soviet Union, many countries began to delink themselves from super power rivalry.

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- Pakistan's membership of the CENTO put it to a difficult test of its Islamic enthusiasm verses national interest. The entire Arab world (except Iraq) kept safe distance from the Pact because they realized the US and Britain to be the powers behind Israel. Pakistan's decision to join the Pact isolated it from the major Arab nations.

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- The period of alliances had pushed Pakistan heavily under the US influence. The cost of alliance was more than actual gain. Pakistan earned ill will of a number of countries. It forced Pakistan to minimize its participation in SEATO and CENTO and open new avenues for a more assertive role in world affairs.
 - Despite its strained relations with the Arabs, its friendship with Turkey and Iran, two other non-Arab countries of the region, continued to grow during this phase due to their common pro-western policies. Even during this period, however, it consistently supported the cause of the Palestinians in all international forums.

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- However, Pakistan could not achieve its main objective i.e. security by joining these alliance systems.
 - These agreements turned out to be useless when Pakistan-India clashed in 1965 and 1971. No country came to Pakistan's rescue. After its defeat in 1971 Pakistan instead on depending on any one power began a massive venture of arms shopping.
 - Due to this defense policy, expenditure raised and socio-economic needs of the country suffered.

PHASE III

Era of Bilateralism 1963-1978

- During that period, Pakistan lessened its dependence on the Western Alliance System and developed close and cordial relations with China as an alternative source of support against India. The US adopted an even-handed policy toward the Pakistan and India and subsequently suspended military assistance to both countries.

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- During this phase, Pakistan was looking for new friends in the international arena because the old alignments appeared inadequate in terms of its security requirements. It responded to Soviet gestures of friendship and its relations with the Soviet Union improved considerably. After the 1965 Indo-Pakistan war, Moscow offered to mediate between India and Pakistan. Soviet Union played a vital role in the Tashkent agreement of January 1966. Also, it once again turned to the Third World and Middle East countries.

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- Its relations with the Arab world started to grow stronger. During the 1967 Arab-Israeli war it extended all out support for the Arabs.
 - With the assumption of power by Z.A. Bhutto, Pakistan charted a new course in its foreign relations. Immediately, after coming to power, he took a tour of 20 Muslim countries of the Middle East which he called **‘a mission of renaissance of relations with the Muslim world’**. In 1972, Pakistan withdrew from the Commonwealth, SEATO and recognized the Socialist Governments of North Korea and North Vietnam.

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- Bhutto missed no opportunity to extend total support for Arabs during the Ramadan war of 1973 against Israel and readily exploited the situation to enhance Pakistan's role in the Islamic world by hosting the **second Islamic Summit Conference in Lahore in 1974**.
 - US Pakistan relationship was not as cordial as they were during 1950's and 1960's. Twice the US suspended military aid to Pakistan during 1965 and 1971 Indo-Pakistan war.
 - One advantage Pakistan achieved during this Era was its increasing economic and political relations with the Third World and the Socialist Countries.

PHASE IV

Era of Non Alignment 1979-1989

- The US military, economic and political influence was liquidated in Iran in 1979. After the revolution, Iran announced its withdrawal from CENTO. Also, CENTO has become ineffective owing to the top priority given by the US in the Middle East and the Gulf. After Iran's withdrawal, Pakistan also decided to withdraw, enabling it to join NAM.
- Pakistan was included in the NAM at the Havana Summit of September, 1979. Three reasons behind joining NAM are:
 - Changing geo-political situation in South-West Asia. The Revolution in Afghanistan (April, 1978) and Islamic Revolution in Iran (February, 1979) also compelled Pakistan to join.

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- Pakistan did not want to remain cut off from the midstream of politics in the Third World. By joining NAM, Pakistan hoped to acquire recognition and prestige in the Third World.
 - Internally, several political groups had demanded Pakistan's withdrawal from the Western Alliance System and wanted the country to join NAM.
 - Pakistan's relations with US had deteriorated especially after the suspension of American economic aid in 1979 as a protest against Pakistan's nuclear program. But the situation dramatically changed after Russian intervention in Afghanistan which forced USA to reorient its relation with Pakistan. Asia emerged as a region of high priority for the US policy-makers.

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- While maintaining its membership in the NAM, Pakistan signed a 3.2 (1982) and 4.02 (1986) billion dollar package deal with the US. After Russian intervention in Afghanistan, the US did not object Pakistan's nuclear program- in fact it received a big boost.
 - The nuclear and missile system program was started to maintain the balance of power in the region.
 - Pak-China relations were promoted due to unsafe borders and to counter the power imbalance of South-Asia.

During this period, following were the main objectives of Pakistan's foreign policy:

- Friendly and cordial relations with the People's Republic of China
- Close relations with US
- Better economic and political ties with the Muslim countries
- Policy of Non-Alignment in world affairs
- Security

PHASE V

Era of Post Cold War 1990-2001

- The cold war era which lasted for around 45 years collapsed in 1990-1991 as the result of following events:
 - Gulf crisis and Gulf war which proved the supremacy of US-led coalition against Iraq. The UN Security Council passed several resolutions against Iraq without any resistance from Moscow or Beijing.
 - The dismantling of Warsaw Pact and Soviet Disintegration. The collapse of communist rule in the former USSR and the subsequent emergence of 15 sovereign states (6 Muslim and 9 non-Muslim) also encouraged the US to assert its position in the region.

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- When the cold war ended in 1990, Pakistan lost precious time in adjusting to the new realities. As the result Pakistan was isolated, pressurized to roll-back its nuclear program, threatened with the terrorist tag, silenced on Kashmir, abandoned in Afghanistan and seen with suspicion even in parts of the Arab and Islamic world.
 - For Pakistan, the post-cold war situation led to many challenges in context of its relations with India, US and China. The US military and economic aid suspension against Pakistan, new trends in US-Indo relations and that in relations between Beijing and New Delhi should be seen in the perspective of new development priorities.

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- It was pointed out by President Ghulam Ishaque Khan of Pakistan that if the New World Order means the domination or monopoly of one power on the rest of the world then it couldn't be acceptable to Pakistan.
 - But given economic, military, and technological superiority of the West compared to the developing world, Pakistan and other countries belonging to the non-western world are not in a position to challenge unfair acts of big powers.
 - There are also reports with regard to the refusal of G-8 countries (US, Britain, Canada, Japan, Italy, Russia, France and Germany) to render economic and technological assistance to the developing world.

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- The least developed countries that are dependent on the west for technology and aid, will find it difficult to change the course of things in the world politics.
 - On May 18, 1998 and again on 30 May, 1998, Pakistan successfully conducted nuclear tests at Chagai hills in Balochistan in reaction to Indian nuclear bomb testing. As reaction of this event USA clamped economic and military sanctions on Pakistan under the **Pressler Amendment** (which widened the conventional gap between India and Pakistan).
 - That same year, the intensification of the freedom movement in occupied Kashmir led to the massive deployment of Indian troops in occupied Kashmir.

PHASE VI

Era of Global Anti-Terrorism 2001 onwards

The 11 September 2001 attacks in New York and Washington placed Pakistan in grave foreign policy dilemmas. Pakistan's strategic policy brought it face to face with the US ultimatums:

- Pakistan should disregard the Taliban
- Discard Islamic Jihad
- Discard Islamic Fundamentalists and
- Become an accomplice in the American military intervention in Afghanistan or else face the consequences.

Pakistan boldly decided to join the international coalition against the war on terrorism and became a frontline state in this fight.

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- In November, 2001 the US led multi-nation force succeeded in removing Taliban from power in Afghanistan and a multi-ethnic interim government under Karzai had been installed in Kabul. In this campaign Pakistan provided bases for launching military operations against Taliban-once Pakistan's ally in Afghanistan. In March-April 2003, USA and Britain forces invaded Iraq and dislodged anti-American Saddam regime.
 - In these two events, General Pervaiz Musharraf fully supported USA. By seizing this opportunity, Pakistan reached a position of eminence on the international stage.

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- For proper functioning of foreign policy, three elements are vital:
 - 1: Any foreign policy to be successful it has to be rooted in its domestic base which includes political stability, national consensus, sound economy and quality of leadership.
 - 2: Relationship with distant Godfathers are no substitute for bonds in the region of a country's location. Pakistan can have the best relationship with the US, but it loses out on its neighborhood, with hostility from Iran and Afghanistan, distancing from Central Asia and a cooling off with China, then it would end up undermining its core interests.

3: Countries deflect pressures and threats through skillful diplomacy, using innovative and novel means to promote their interests.

- In the past 40 years, Pakistan's foreign policy has largely revolved around a triangle of India (countering the adversary), China ("the enemy of my enemy is a friend") and the US (serving Washington's interests, as in 1960s, 1971, 1980s and currently).
- Pakistan needs to build more solid and enduring foundations of its foreign policy.

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- In the last few years, India has built bridges with Iran, China, Afghanistan, Tajikistan and the UAE in Pakistan's vicinity, while at the same time expanding its diplomatic leverage by forming a new India, Brazil and South Africa Dialogue forum (IBSA).
 - An effective foreign policy requires stability and a national consensus on issues. Economic and technical development on the basis of self-reliance is equally important to advance the welfare of our people and to back up our international position.

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- During the past three decades the Afghanistan issue, Kashmir struggle for freedom and Pakistan's nuclear policy has made the borders of the country more open to problems.
 - Recent development in the world and region has put the country in the hot water.
 - Due to continues political disturbance and wars in Afghanistan has created serious socio-economic issues for Pakistan.
 - Pakistan has been over burdened by unnecessary foreign aid which has only turned out to be a trap.

International/Regional Organizations & Foreign policy

- Pakistan is an active member of the United Nations. It was a member of the CENTO and SEATO military alliances. Its alliance with the United States was especially close after the Soviets invaded the neighboring country of Afghanistan.
- In 1964, Pakistan signed the Regional Cooperation for Development (RCD) Pact with Turkey and Iran, when all three countries were closely allied with the U.S., and as neighbors of the Soviet Union, worried about the expansion policy of USSR in the region.

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- To this day, Pakistan has a close relationship with Turkey. RCD became obsolete after the Iranian Revolution, and a Pakistani-Turkish initiative led to the founding of the Economic Cooperation Organization (ECO) in 1985.
 - Pakistan is the leading member of the Coffee Club to oppose Indian membership in the United Nations Security Council.
 - Pakistan is an important member of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC), a major non-NATO ally of the war against terrorism, and has a highly disciplined military, which is the world's eighth-largest standing military force.
 - Pakistan is also an active member of SSARC and SCO.

Current Focusing points

- The major focus of Pakistan's foreign policy is security against external and internal challenges to its national identity, territorial , integrity and independence.
- Pakistan highlights sovereign equality of states, bilateralism, mutuality of interests, and non-interference in each other's domestic affairs as the cardinal features of its foreign policy.
- Pakistan maintains a strong faith in the principles enunciated in the United Nations Charter and takes an active part in the deliberations of the UN and other International and regional organizations.

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- The current regional and global situation once again presents Pakistan with a formidable challenge at the foreign policy front. Foremost among them are:
 - The rising tension between India and Pakistan and the unilateral abrogation of the special status of Kashmir by revoking Article 370 and Article 35(A) of the Indian Constitution.
 - The negative balance of trade with USA, China, India and other regional and global countries.

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- Internal strength of a country in terms of its economy, political stability and strategic cohesion.
 - Mobilization and empowerment of the people through promotion of fair democratic practices
 - Building the Pakistan-China strategic partnership
 - Managing Sino-US rivalry
 - Peaceful political settlement in Afghanistan

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- Combating extremism and terrorism
 - Iran-Saudi Rivalry
 - Economic diplomacy
 - Revive its traditional leadership role in the Muslim world
 - Climate change and environmental hazards

Way forward

- Integrity of state: internal
- Security of borders
- Development of state
- Protecting the honor of state
- Safeguarding the national interest
- Kashmir issue
- To acquire peaceful methods while dealing with international conflicts
- Balance relationship with powerful states-China & U.S

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- to promote relationship with Muslim countries
 - to promote international peace
 - to help Afghanistan in its stability process
 - strengthen relations with neighboring states including India
 - provide safe passage to energy deficit states- energy corridor